THE GAP

MICRO IMMERSION SERIES · DISCIPLINE NO. 01

THE ART OF EIGHT LIMBS · CHIANG MAI, THAILAND

Muay Thai.

14 Days in the North.

You come to Chiang Mai to learn to fight. But what Muay Thai actually teaches — what every fighter who has trained seriously will tell you — is that the discipline is a system for becoming calm under pressure. You learn to stop reacting and start reading. To be present when something real is happening. That skill transfers to everything else.

14	8	2×	2	1
DAYS	SPOTS	DAILY	FIGHT NIGHTS	CEREMONY

No prior Muay Thai experience required. No martial arts background. The only requirement: show up to every session, do the work, and let the 14 days be what they are.

apply@bridgethegap.com

THE PHILOSOPHY

Why fight?

Muay Thai is called *the art of eight limbs*. Fists, elbows, knees, shins — every striking surface of the human body put into service as a weapon. It is one of the oldest martial arts still practiced in its original form. Thai fighters have been competing since the 16th century, and the techniques used by professional fighters at Lumpini Stadium in Bangkok tonight are the same ones your Kru will teach you on Day 2.

But the reason this discipline is in THE GAP framework has nothing to do with fighting. It has to do with what serious training — the kind where you show up twice a day, six days a week, and don't stop when it's hard — does to a person's relationship with pressure, discomfort, and self-knowledge.

Most people have never been in a situation where they had to stay calm while something was actively trying to knock them off. Muay Thai puts you in that situation repeatedly, with progressively less padding and progressively more consequence, until calm under pressure stops being a phrase and becomes a physical skill. You stop thinking. You breathe. You respond instead of react. That's what you take home.

THE GAP · CORE BELIEF

"The goal isn't to become a fighter. The goal is to discover what happens to you when the training is real, the teacher doesn't go easy, and quitting costs you something. That discovery — of what you do when it's actually hard — is the curriculum."

Every discipline in THE GAP framework is chosen because it teaches something that can't be learned in a classroom. Muay Thai teaches presence, composure,

and the ability to read another person while staying inside your own body. These are not small things. They are foundational.

The Wai Kru

Before every professional Muay Thai bout in Thailand — from the smallest village ring to the main stage at Rajadamnern Stadium — both fighters perform the Wai Kru. It is a ritual honoring the teacher (Kru), asking for protection, and centering the mind before combat. Each fighter's Wai Kru is unique — a personal expression of their lineage, their belief, and their relationship to the sport.

The group learns the Wai Kru on Day 2. The Kru explains the meaning of the mongkong (the headband placed on the fighter by the teacher before a bout) and the prachiads (sacred rope armbands). On Day 12, the full ceremony is performed in the ring, with the Kru present.

The Wai Kru is not a cultural exercise or a photo opportunity. By the time you perform it, you will understand what you're doing and why. That's the only condition under which it means anything.

01

Adventure + Adrenaline

Twice-daily training with Krus who have competed at Lumpini. Sparring on Day 8. Two professional fight nights ringside. Summit Doi Inthanon — Thailand's highest peak — on your rest day. Waterfall swim at 2,500m. The training is the adrenaline.

02

Travel + Encounter

Train at a camp where the fighters eat, sleep, and live. Walk Chiang Mai's Old City before dawn. Learn the Wai Kru from the inside. Eat khao soi and larb at the places locals go. Understand the culture that produced this discipline — not just the discipline itself.

03

Service + Giving Back

Day 13: travel to Master Boon's hill tribe camp in Mae Hong Son and run a training session for local children. You teach what you learned. You don't take the experience and leave — you add to something that was already happening before you arrived.

THE TEACHER

Master Boon and Boon Lanna.

Master Boon

BOON LANNA MUAY THAI
SARAPHI DISTRICT
CHIANG MAI

Master Boon grew up in the hill tribes of northern Thailand, training in the traditional Muay Thai methods that long predate the modern sport. His teacher was Andy Thompson — a former champion whose lineage runs through the old northern style, closer to Muay Boran (ancient Muay Thai) than the sport version practiced at Lumpini today. Boon carries that tradition forward while training fighters who compete at the highest levels.

His gym, Boon Lanna, is in Saraphi District — 13km south of Chiang Mai, surrounded by rice paddies and mountain views, away from the tourist traffic of the city center. The Krus who work under him have competed at Lumpini and Rajadamnern. They do not train people to look good in photos. They train people to fight well — which means training them to think clearly when something is coming at them.

Master Boon also operates a dedicated training camp in Mae Hong Son — a rural mountain village in the hills north of Chiang Mai — where he provides fully sponsored Muay Thai training to children from the local hill tribes. The same way he was trained. THE GAP group visits this camp on Day 13 and runs a session for the kids.

TRAINING BASE
Saraphi District, Chiang Mai

LINEAGE
Northern Thai hill tribe tradition

NORTHERN THAI
HILL TRIBE LINEAGE
LUMPINI TRAINED
MAE HONG SON
VILLAGE CAMP

STYLE
Traditional Muay Thai + Muay Boran

VILLAGE CAMP
Mae Hong Son · Sponsored youth program

What the training looks like

Every session begins with a 3km run and shadow boxing. The Kru watches how your body moves before he corrects anything — your instincts tell him more than your technique does. Sessions are built around the fundamental weapons of Muay Thai: the teep (push kick — used to control distance), the round kick (the primary power weapon — generated through full hip rotation, not the foot), the jab and cross (used to set up the legs), the elbow (used in close), and the clinch.

The clinch deserves special attention. Most beginners ignore it. Most fights are decided by it. Muay Thai clinch work means you are physically locked with another person — arms inside or outside, heads close, each trying to off-balance the other for a knee strike or a throw. Learning to operate in the clinch means learning to stay composed and functional while someone is quite literally trying to upend you. It is the most uncomfortable and most instructive part of the training.

Sessions run 7:00–9:00am and 4:00–6:00pm, six days a week. The midday break is for active recovery: Thai massage, ice baths, namman muay (Thai boxing liniment applied to sore muscles), food, and rest. This is how professional fighters train. The rhythm is not brutal — it is sustainable. Sustainable enough to do for years.

> **On recovery:** Thai fighters apply namman muay — a traditional boxing liniment made from camphor and menthol — to their muscles after every session. Ice baths reduce inflammation. Two-hour traditional Thai massage works the deep muscle tissue. These are not wellness add-ons. They are the methods Thai fighters have used for centuries to train twice a day, every day, for their entire careers.

THE ITINERARY · WEEK ONE · DAYS 1–7

Foundation.

The first week is about building the base — technically, physically, and mentally. By Day 7 you will have trained six full days, watched a professional fight night, climbed Thailand's highest peak, and learned the Wai Kru. You will also be more tired than you've ever been. That is correct.

01

ARRIVAL

You Land

CHIANG MAI
NO TRAINING
GROUP DINNER
EARLY SLEEP

ORIENTATION

Arrive. Eat. Rest. Morning session is at 7:00am.

Ground transport from Chiang Mai International Airport to camp in Saraphi District. Check in, drop gear. The camp is not a resort — it is where fighters live and train. Mountain views, a river nearby, no tourist traffic. Group dinner at the local restaurant the fighters use — khao soi and sai ua, the food of northern Thailand. No phones at the table. Introductions around the table. Early sleep. The alarm goes off at 6:30.

02

FIRST CONTACT

The Kru Reads You

AM TRAINING
DOI SUTHEP
WAI KRU EVENING

WEEK 1 · FOUNDATION

The Kru watches how you move before he teaches you anything.

Morning: movement assessment. Shadow boxing, stance, basic teep. The Kru does not correct much — he is watching your instincts, your balance, how you respond to pressure. This tells him more than anything else. Everyone starts from zero regardless of prior martial arts experience.

Afternoon: Doi Suthep — Chiang Mai's guardian temple, built in 1383 at 1,073m above the city. 309 steps up through the jungle. Views of the entire valley. Evening: the Kru explains the Wai Kru. The mongkong, the prachiads, the sequence of movements. What fighters are doing when they bow and circle the ring. Why it matters.

07:00–09:00
Assessment Session
Shadow boxing, stance, first teep

14:00–16:30
Doi Suthep
309 steps, temple visit, valley views

EVENING
Wai Kru Teaching
With the Kru — ritual, lineage, meaning

03

FOUNDATION

The Weapons

AM + PM TRAINING

OLD CITY EVENING

WEEK 1 · FOUNDATION

Stance. Teep. Jab-cross. The round kick. This is where it starts.

First full double-session day. Morning: stance and footwork — the foundation everything else depends on. A fighter whose footwork is wrong cannot do anything else right. Afternoon: the teep and the jab-cross as setups, then the round kick in detail. The round kick is Muay Thai's signature weapon — it is not a soccer kick. It comes from full hip rotation through the shin, not the foot. Slow, correct repetitions until the mechanics are in the body.

Evening: Chiang Mai Old City — the square city inside the ancient moat. Night market. Khao soi at a stall the locals queue at. Walk the moat by moonlight. The city is alive at night in a way that the daytime doesn't show.

07:00–09:00

Stance + Footwork

Heavy bag, mirror work

16:00–18:00

Teep + Round Kick

Pad work introduction with Kru

EVENING

Old City

Night market, khao soi, moat walk

04

FIGHT NIGHT 1

Thaphae Stadium

AM TRAINING
THAI MASSAGE
RINGSIDE 21:00

WEEK 1 · ENCOUNTER

Watch the real thing. You'll train differently tomorrow morning.

Morning session: combinations and defense. How to use the teep to control distance. How to read a round kick coming and not panic. Afternoon: 2-hour traditional Thai massage at a proper clinic — the therapist will find muscles you didn't know you had. This is not optional. This is recovery.

Evening: Thaphae Boxing Stadium, ringside. Professional Muay Thai — real fighters, full Thai crowd, gambling on every bout. Watch the Wai Kru. Watch how fighters use the clinch to change position. Watch the footwork of the fighter who wins. You know enough now to see things most spectators miss. Stay for every bout.

07:00–09:00
Combinations + Defense
Teep control, reading the round kick

14:00–16:00
Thai Massage
2-hour traditional — deep tissue recovery

21:00
Thaphae Stadium
Ringside · Full professional card

05

THE CLINCH

Close Contact

AM + PM TRAINING
ICE BATH PROTOCOL
DEBRIEF

WEEK 1 · DEPTH

The clinch begins. The part most people ignore. The part that decides most fights.

The clinch is introduced. You will be physically locked with a partner — arms inside or outside, heads close, each trying to off-balance the other for a knee or a throw. It is uncomfortable. Most beginners either go rigid (wrong) or go loose (wrong). The Kru teaches you how to be firm and relaxed at the same time — how to maintain control of your own body while absorbing the movement of another person's. This takes a long time to understand. It starts today.

Ice bath protocol starts this morning: 4 minutes before training, 4 minutes after. Cold exposure at this frequency significantly accelerates muscle recovery between sessions. It also teaches something about deciding to do hard things voluntarily. Evening debrief: what worked, what the body is telling you, what you noticed about yourself when the training was difficult.

07:00–09:00
Clinch Introduction
Partner work, balance, knee entry

16:00–18:00
Clinch + Combinations
Linking the ground game to striking

EVENING
Group Debrief
What's landing. What the body needs.

06

POWER DAY

The Elbow

AM + PM TRAINING

LOCAL COOK EVENING

WEEK 1 · DEPTH

The elbow — Muay Thai's most dangerous weapon. Why it works and when to use it.

The elbow is the weapon that separates Muay Thai from every other striking art. At close range, when a punch is too long, the elbow is already there. It is generated through a full body rotation — the same hip mechanics as the round kick, applied at a completely different range. Once you feel it land on a pad correctly, you understand why fighters say the elbow changes everything about close-range fighting.

Evening: group cook at a local family's home — a family who has been hosting Muay Thai travelers for 20 years. Northern Thai food from scratch: sticky rice pounded by hand, larb, nam prik noom (roasted green chili dip), gaeng hang lay (Burmese-influenced northern curry). They feed you the same food they feed their fighters.

07:00–09:00
Elbow Mechanics
Pad work — horizontal, diagonal, spinning

16:00–18:00
Full Combination Day
All weapons linked in sequence

EVENING
Home Dinner
Northern Thai family — food from scratch

07

REST DAY

Doi Inthanon

NO TRAINING
THAILAND'S HIGHEST PEAK
WATERFALL SWIM

WEEK 1 · ADVENTURE

Summit at 2,565m. The highest point in Thailand. Waterfall on the way down.

No training today. Pre-dawn departure — the summit of Doi Inthanon, Thailand's highest mountain, wrapped in cloud forest at 2,565m. The twin chedis at the top were built for the King and Queen. The summit is cold, misty, quiet. The perspective after 6 days of hard training in a hot gym is something particular.

Wachirathan Waterfall on the descent — a wide, powerful fall into a clear pool, surrounded by jungle. Swim as long as you want. Lunch at a hill tribe village on the road back. Return to camp by mid-afternoon. Optional bag work for those who want it — no obligation. The Kru will tell you: rest is training.

> **Why a rest day matters:** Muscle tissue grows and repairs during rest, not during training. Six consecutive days of twice-daily training without a recovery day produces diminishing returns and increases injury risk. Day 7 is not optional. It is part of the program design.

THE ITINERARY · WEEK TWO · DAYS 8–14

Depth.

The second week is where the training stops being technical and starts being real. Sparring begins. The Wai Kru is performed in the ring. The group travels to Mae Hong Son and teaches. And for those who want it — an amateur bout on Day 14. This is the week that changes something.

08

SPARRING

It Gets Real

AM + PM TRAINING
SPARRING BEGINS
1-ON-1 W/ KRU

WEEK 2 · THE HARD PART

Sparring begins. Light contact. This is when the mental piece opens up.

The Kru pairs you deliberately — not always with someone your size, not always with someone slower than you. Light contact sparring means you are not trying to hurt your partner. You are applying everything you've learned against someone who is responding in real time. The technique either lands or it doesn't. You cannot think fast enough to figure out what to do — you have to let the body do it.

This is the moment people describe when they explain what Muay Thai changed in them. You stop being in your head. You breathe through something coming at you. You start reading the other person instead of waiting to see what they do. It is not dramatic. It is just real. And it transfers — to every other situation where something is coming at you and you need to stay present.

07:00–09:00
Technical Sparring
Light contact, Kru supervised, rotation

16:00–18:00
Advanced Pad Work
Combinations, counter-attack, timing

EVENING
1-on-1 with Kru
Individual technical assessment and notes

09

READING

Stop Reacting

AM + PM TRAINING
SPARRING CONTINUES
RIVER AT DUSK

WEEK 2 · DEPTH

Day two of sparring. You're no longer bracing. You start reading.

The difference between Day 8 and Day 9 sparring is usually visible in the way people breathe. On Day 8 most people hold their breath when something comes. On Day 9 they breathe through it. This sounds small. It is not small. Breathing under pressure is the physical expression of composure. The Kru can see it from across the room.

Evening: Mae Ping River, a short walk from camp. Sit on the bank at dusk. There is nothing specific to do. This is one of the last quiet evenings before the week accelerates.

07:00–09:00
Sparring — Reading
Focus on anticipation, not reaction

16:00–18:00
Clinch Sparring
Full clinch rounds — knees and balance

EVENING
Mae Ping River
Dusk. Quiet. No agenda.

10

INTEGRATION

Full Review

AM + PM TRAINING
EXTENDED 1-ON-1
REST

WEEK 2 · INTEGRATION

The Kru tells each person specifically what to fix. Then fixes it.

Full technical review day. The Kru has been watching for 10 days. He knows exactly what each person's weakness is and exactly what to work on. Extended 1-on-1 pad sessions — each person gets more time with the Kru than usual. He is not polite about what needs to change. This is the most useful training session of the camp for most people.

Afternoon: rest. Full rest. Not optional. Not a light bag session. Sleep if you can. The body needs this before the final push of the week.

07:00–09:00
1-on-1 Technical
Extended pad work, individual focus

16:00–18:00
Sparring — Full Application
Everything linked, full rounds

AFTERNOON
Rest
Mandatory. The body earns it.

11

FIGHT NIGHT 2

Kalare Stadium

AM TRAINING
MASSAGE
RINGSIDE 21:00

WEEK 2 · ENCOUNTER

Second fight night. You see something completely different from Day 4.

Morning training. Rest and massage in the afternoon. Kalare Night Bazaar Boxing Stadium in the evening — an older, louder venue than Thaphae, local crowd, atmosphere that feels less curated. Every fight night in Chiang Mai is different.

What changes between the first and second fight night is what you are able to see. On Day 4 you watched. Tonight you will notice the footwork. You will see how a fighter enters the clinch. You will notice when a fighter is calm and when they're not — and you'll know the difference because you've felt it from the inside. The fights look different to you now. That's the immersion working.

07:00–09:00
Fight Prep Training
Sharpening, speed, timing

14:00–16:00
Thai Massage
Recovery before the final days

21:00
Kalare Stadium
Ringside · Full card

12

THE CEREMONY

Wai Kru

LONGEST TRAINING DAY
FULL CEREMONY
IN THE RING

WEEK 2 · THE CEREMONY

The hardest training day. Then the Wai Kru — in the ring, with the Kru present.

The longest training day of the camp. Double sessions, extended duration, maximum intensity. Everyone is tired. Everyone shows up. There is a point in every immersion where the training stops being something you're doing and becomes something you're inside. This is that day.

Evening: full traditional Wai Kru ceremony in the ring. The Kru places the mongkong on each person's head individually — the same act performed by every Muay Thai teacher before every professional bout. The group performs the Wai Kru sequence together: three circuits of the ring, arms raised, the prayer, the personal dance. By this point the ritual means something because you have done the work it is supposed to honor. That is the only condition under which a ceremony is real.

> **The Wai Kru sequence:** Begins kneeling, facing the teacher. Three circuits of the ring to mark the sacred space. The Wai Kru dance — a personal meditation in movement that each fighter performs as themselves. The mongkong is placed by the Kru and removed only after the bout. The prachiads are tied at the bicep. The bow to the four corners. Then you fight.

DAYS 13–14 · SERVICE AND CLOSING

Give back. Then leave.

13
SERVICE DAY

Mae Hong Son

HILL TRIBE CAMP
FULL DAY
TEACH AND TRAIN

SERVICE + GIVING BACK

Travel to the mountains. Teach what you learned. Don't go easy.

Travel to Mae Hong Son — Master Boon's hill tribe village camp in the mountains north of Chiang Mai. This is where he trains children from the local hill tribes, fully sponsored, the same way he was trained as a child. The camp exists independently of THE GAP. It will exist after you leave.

The group runs a 2-hour training session for the kids. You warm them up. You teach stance and the teep. You run pad rounds with them. You are not coming to perform charity — you are coming to contribute to something that is already serious, already happening, and already mattering. These kids train. Some of them are better than you. That's the point.

Lunch with the families. Walk the village. Return to Chiang Mai in the evening. The drive back through the northern hills takes two hours. Use it.

WHY SERVICE IS NOT OPTIONAL

You don't just take the experience. You add to it.

Every immersion in THE GAP framework ends with the group giving something back to the place and the people who made the experience possible. This is not philanthropy. It is the completion of the learning cycle — you move from student to

teacher, from receiver to contributor. That shift is one of the most significant moments in any serious education. It also makes the experience harder to walk away from unchanged, because you have left something of yourself in it.

At Boon Lanna, that means going to Mae Hong Son and running a session for kids who take Muay Thai more seriously than most adults ever will. They will push you. Let them.

14

CLOSING DAY

Depart

OPTIONAL BOUT
FINAL DEBRIEF
AFTERNOON DEPARTURE

CLOSING

For those who want it: one bout. For everyone: the last conversation.

Morning: optional amateur bout at a local stadium, arranged through Boon Lanna for those who choose to compete. This is not a requirement. It is an offer. Light gloves, experienced referee, no expectation of outcome — just the experience of stepping into a ring in Thailand and doing it for real, once, having earned the preparation. Everyone else comes and supports. It is a different thing to watch someone you've trained alongside for 14 days.

Final group debrief: not a recap of what happened, but a conversation about what changed. What the body knows now that it didn't before. What feels different. What you're taking home that you didn't bring. Departure in the afternoon.

> **What you leave with:** 13 days of twice-daily Muay Thai training under a Kru with real lineage. The Wai Kru — performed properly, in the ring, meaning something. Two professional fight nights from ringside. The summit of Doi Inthanon. Mae Hong Son. The ability to walk into any gym in any country and hold your own. And something else — harder to name, easier to demonstrate. A kind of calm you didn't have when you landed in Chiang Mai.

LOGISTICS · WHAT'S INCLUDED · HOW TO APPLY

Everything you need to know.

LOCATION

Chiang Mai, Thailand

Training base: Saraphi District · 13km south of Chiang Mai International (CNX)

DURATION

14 Days

Arrive Day 1 evening · Depart Day 14 afternoon

GROUP SIZE

8 spots

Intentionally small. The Kru knows your name and your weak side.

INVESTMENT

$3,400

All-inclusive except flights and travel insurance. See below for full breakdown.

AGE RANGE

17–24

No prior Muay Thai, martial arts, or combat sports experience required.

FITNESS BASELINE

Reasonably active

Able to run 3km continuously. The training builds the rest. Elite fitness is not required.

TRAINING SCHEDULE

2× daily, 6 days/week

07:00–09:00 AM · 16:00–18:00 PM · Sunday off (Doi Inthanon)

APPLY

apply@bridgethegap.com

Brief note on who you are and why this immersion. We respond within 48 hours.

What's included

- **All Muay Thai training**
  13 days of twice-daily sessions with Kru Boon's team. Gloves, shin guards, and all striking equipment provided.
- **Accommodation**
  Private rooms near camp in Saraphi District. Clean, simple, close to the ring. No resort — a fighter's camp.
- **Daily meals**
- **2 × Thai massage**

Breakfast and lunch at camp. Group dinners together. Northern Thai food throughout.

Days 4 and 11. 2-hour traditional sessions at a proper clinic. The recovery method fighters use.

- **Two fight nights, ringside**
  Thaphae Boxing Stadium (Day 4) and Kalare Night Bazaar Stadium (Day 11). Professional bouts, full card.

- **Doi Inthanon — full day**
  Summit at 2,565m, waterfall swim on the descent. Transport from and to camp included.

- **Mae Hong Son — full day**
  Hill tribe camp visit, full teaching session, lunch with families. Transport included.

- **Wai Kru ceremony**
  Full traditional ceremony in the ring. Mongkong and prachiads. With the Kru. On Day 12.

- **Doi Suthep temple visit**
  Day 2 afternoon. 800 years old. 309 steps. One of the most significant temple sites in Thailand.

- **Home dinner — Day 6**
  Northern Thai family, food cooked from scratch. The same family has been hosting fighters for 20 years.

- **Airport transfers**
  Day 1 arrival pickup and Day 14 departure drop-off at Chiang Mai International (CNX).

- **Recovery protocol**
  Ice baths, namman muay liniment, and structured rest built into the daily schedule.

What to bring

Hand wraps — the Kru will show you how to wrap correctly on Day 1. Lightweight athletic shorts and t-shirts (you will sweat through them). Running shoes. Sandals for off-training hours. A towel. The camp provides all striking equipment: gloves, shin guards, head guards, heavy bags, pads. Pack light. You are training, not touring.

What is not included

International flights to and from Chiang Mai (CNX). Travel insurance — required, purchase before departure. Personal spending. The optional amateur bout on Day 14 is included at no additional cost for those who choose to participate.

THE GAP · MICRO IMMERSION SERIES · MUAY THAI

8 spots. Chiang Mai. Are you in?

You do not have to be a fighter. You do not have to be fit enough yet. You have to be willing to show up at 7:00am every morning, to do the work when it is genuinely difficult, and to let the 14 days be what they are. That is the only requirement.

REGISTER INTEREST / APPLY
apply@bridgethegap.com

PROGRAM WEBSITE
bridgethegap.com

THE GAP

BRIDGE THE GAP · MUAY THAI · CHIANG MAI, THAILAND